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Lecture 5: Participation and Representation (FK)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: OD ch. 6 (*Institutions of Participation and Representation*)

Theme of the lecture: Why do some citizens participate while others don't? Why are some interests represented while others aren't? We examine how different institutions — specifically electoral and party systems — shape political participation and representation.

OD Ch. 6 — Institutions of Participation and Representation

Book: Orvis & Drogus, *Introducing Comparative Politics*, 5th ed., ch. 6.

Chapter résumé

Looks at the three institutions through which democracies channel **participation and representation** — **electoral systems, parties/party systems, and civil society (interest groups)** — and asks which best represent ordinary and marginalised citizens. It opens with *why anyone participates at all* (a collective-action problem), then its analytic core: how **electoral systems** (plurality/SMD · majoritarian · PR · mixed) convert votes into seats and thereby shape the **number of parties** (Duverger's Law), proportionality, stability, and the representation of women & minorities. It classifies **party systems**, surveys how parties mobilise (programmatic / clientelist / populist) amid a "crisis of party democracy," contrasts **pluralist vs neocorporatist** interest-group systems, and closes on the master **trade-off (Powell): diverse representation ⇒ clear accountability**.

★ The heart of the chapter: institutions decide who participates and whose interests get represented. The **electoral system** is the master lever — **SMD/plurality** squeezes politics toward *two parties + clear accountability but wasted votes*; **PR** opens it to *many parties + proportional, diverse representation but coalition instability* (Duverger's Law). Underneath sits one unavoidable **trade-off (Powell): broad representation ⇒ clear accountability/governability**.

The red thread. Two questions run through the chapter. ① **Why participate (or not)?** — voting is individually "irrational" (a collective-action problem), so *institutions* raise or lower the cost (PR & simple systems → higher turnout). ② **Whose interests get represented?** — the electoral system → party system → interest-group system chain decides. For any case ask: **how do votes become seats · how many parties result · who gets left out (small parties, women, minorities) · and what's traded off (representation vs accountability)?**

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- The electoral-system menu: SMD plurality (FPTP) · majoritarian (two-round / alternative vote) · proportional representation (PR) · mixed/semiproportional.

- Duverger's Law — SMD → two parties; PR → multiparty.
- **Party systems** — dominant-party · two-party · multiparty; **sociological** (cleavages) vs **institutional** (electoral rules) origins.
- **Mobilisation types** — programmatic · patronage/clientelist · populist.
- **Interest groups: pluralism** (many, neutral state — US) vs **neocorporatism** (few peak associations bargain with the state — Germany).
- The Powell trade-off — representation/participation ⇌ accountability/governability.

Section-by-section main points

Why participate? — the collective-action problem

Core: voting is individually "**irrational**" (Downs) — one vote rarely decides anything — so participation is a **collective-action problem** that *institutions* must overcome.

- People vote anyway for **expressive/solidaristic** reasons, charismatic leaders, and to avoid the **emotional cost** of not participating (guilt, exclusion).
- **Institutions shape turnout:** complex systems depress it among the less-educated; **PR/mixed systems raise it** (fewer "wasted votes"); parties & interest groups lower the cost of finding and acting on your interests.

Electoral systems — the core of the chapter ★

Core: the electoral system is the master lever — *on what basis are you represented* (a **district**, a **party/idea**, or a **group**), and *how do votes become seats*?

System	Votes → seats	Parties (Duverger)	Proportionality	Turnout	Women/minorities	Cases
SMD plurality (FPTP)	most votes in each district wins (no majority needed)	two parties	low (wasted votes)	lower	worse	<u>UK</u> , <u>US</u> , <u>India</u>
Majoritarian (two-round / AV ranked-choice)	need 50%+1 → runoff or reallocate	~two blocs	low-medium	—	—	France
Proportional (PR) — closed/open list	seats = vote share (national/large districts, a threshold)	multiparty	high	higher	better	<u>Israel</u> , <u>Brazil</u> (open)
<u>Mixed / semiproportional</u>	SMD seats + party-list PR	multiparty	high (<u>compensatory</u> , Germany) / medium (<u>noncompensatory</u> , Japan)	higher	—	Germany, Japan

- **SMD/FPTP:** *strengths* — strong voter–representative link, single-party government (efficient, accountable). *Weaknesses* — **wasted votes, disproportionality** (a party can win many seats on ~35% pluralities; a broad-but-thin party wins almost none), gerrymandering, fewer women/minorities.
- **PR:** *strengths* — few wasted votes, **higher turnout**, far **more women & minorities** (lists + quotas), more information/positions, more egalitarian policy. *Weaknesses* — no identifiable individual rep, **coalition instability**, small extremist parties gain outsized leverage.
- **Mixed:** two ballots (a district candidate + a party list) — blends a personal rep with proportional fairness; **Germany's compensatory** version tops seats up to full proportionality, **Japan's noncompensatory** version keeps SMD & PR separate (less proportional). **AV/ranked-choice** wastes fewer votes than FPTP (Maine 2018 elected the first US Congress seat by AV).
- **Redistribution link (Iversen & Soskice — from Lecture 4):** PR → the middle class allies with the poor → bigger welfare states; majoritarian → middle allies with the rich → less. A key reason electoral systems shape *policy*, not just seats (the Sweden vs US welfare puzzle).

■ Duverger's Law — and its limits

Core: SMD/plurality → two parties (small parties get squeezed out and voters stop "wasting" votes on them); PR → multiparty.

- **But not deterministic:** it holds in *established* democracies; in **new/diverse** democracies voters aren't strategic (ethnic/identity voting persists), so FPTP can still produce many parties (Moser & Scheiner) — see **India**. And it can break even in old democracies (**France 2017:** Macron's one-year-old party upended a near-two-party system).

■ Party systems

Core: classify by **number & strength:** **dominant-party** (S. Africa ANC) • **two-party** (US, UK) • **multiparty** (Italy). Origins are **sociological** (social **cleavages** — economic everywhere; + religion in some places → multiparty) and **institutional** (Duverger's electoral incentives).

■ How parties mobilise — and the "crisis of party democracy"

Core: parties win support three ways — **programmatic** (ideas/ideology) • **patronage/clientelist** (material benefits for votes — common in poorer/newer democracies) • **populist** (a personalist leader, "the people" vs "corrupt elites," crisis rhetoric, "bad manners").

- **Crisis:** only ~20% trust parties (though ~80% value democracy); falling loyalty/membership/turnout, rising **volatility** and **far-right populism** (post-2015 refugee crisis). Debates: **dealignment vs realignment**; catch-all → "**cartel parties**."

■ Civil society & interest groups — pluralism vs neocorporatism

Core: beyond parties, organised **interest groups** represent society — in two rival models.

- **Pluralism** (US): **many** competing groups, a **neutral** state; easy entry but fragmented clout, and business is inherently privileged.
- **Neocorporatism** (Germany, N. Europe): a **few large hierarchical peak associations** negotiate **binding** deals with the state; more influence (esp. for labour vs business) but less participatory. (*State corporatism = the mandated, authoritarian version.*)

- **Social capital** debate: Putnam's *Bowling Alone* (civic decline) vs critics ("**Kicking in Groups**" — activity just moved to new forms).

| The master trade-off (Powell)

Core: systems open to **diversity** (PR · multiparty · pluralism) maximise **representation & participation** but blur **accountability & governability**; **majoritarian** systems (FPTP · two-party) do the reverse. *There is no free lunch — every design chooses a point on this line.* The chapter's most robust finding: **PR represents women far better than SMD** (India goes further with **reserved seats**).

Cases & examples

Why these cases are here — **circle them back**. Each shows **one electoral/party system in action** and *who it represents vs leaves out*. Read each for: *which system · how votes became seats · who got left out*.

Case	Electoral system	Party system	What it shows
UK	SMD/FPTP	two-party	extreme disproportionality (UKIP 12.6% → 1 seat)
Germany	mixed compensatory PR	multiparty	how mixed PR lets new parties (Greens, AfD) in
Japan	mixed noncompensatory	dominant (LDP)	more majoritarian; Duverger working haltingly
India	SMD/FPTP + federal	multiparty	Duverger's limits in a diverse democracy; reserved seats
Brazil	open-list PR (no threshold)	fragmented	weak-party fragmentation (30 parties) + populism
Israel	pure closed-list PR	hyper-multiparty	PR instability under extreme diversity

- **UK — SMD/FPTP.** The paradigm two-party FPTP system: modest vote margins → big seat majorities → single-party government. But it's wildly **disproportional** — in **2015, UKIP won 12.6% of the vote → 1 seat**, while the **SNP won fewer votes → 56 seats** (geographically concentrated in Scotland). → *SMD/FPTP → disproportionality, wasted votes, majoritarian governance.*
- **Germany — mixed compensatory PR.** Designed after Weimar with a **5% threshold** + compensatory mixed PR → a stable multiparty system. The **Greens (1983)** got in *because* the semiproportional system let them clear the threshold (unlike Britain's Greens); by **2017** the two big parties fell to a record **54%**, and the far-right **AfD** won its first seats. → *Mixed PR sustains a multiparty system and lets new/ideological parties gain representation.*
- **Japan — mixed noncompensatory.** The **LDP dominated 1955–93** via factions & clientelism; the **1994 reform** (300 SMD + 180 PR, *noncompensatory*) pushed toward two parties — the **DPJ won 308/480 in 2009**, but the **LDP swept back in 2012** ("lucky, not popular" — a split opposition). → *Noncompensatory mixed = more majoritarian than Germany; Duverger's Law working haltingly.*
- **India — FPTP in a diverse federation.** FPTP "should" give two parties, but **huge diversity + federalism** yields many *state-level* two-party fights that aggregate into a **national multiparty** system (parties: 50 in 1952 → 342 in 2009). **BJP (Modi) 2014: 31% of the vote → 52% of seats** under FPTP. **120 of ~600 seats** are **reserved** for lower castes/tribes. → *Duverger's limits in a new/diverse democracy; reserved-seat representation.*
- **Brazil — open-list PR, no threshold.** No incentive for intra-party cooperation → extreme fragmentation (**30 parties by 2018**) and weak, local parties (a third of legislators switched parties 1989–95). Recession + the "car wash" scandal → mass protests → **Rousseff impeached (2016)** → outsider populist **Bolsonaro won 2018** atop a tiny party. → *Open-list PR's weak-party fragmentation + accountability failure + populism.*

- **Israel — pure PR.** The whole country is **one district**, a 120-seat Knesset, **3.25% threshold** → ~a dozen parties win; governments = a big party + 3–6 small ones, lasting ~2 years; **2019 produced three elections in one year.** → *PR's instability under extreme diversity — the cost of maximal proportionality.*

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Collective-action problem	Individuals rationally don't act (vote) though all suffer if none do
Electoral system	Legal mechanism translating votes into offices/seats
Single-member district (SMD)	Each district elects one representative
Plurality / FPTP	Most votes wins (no majority needed)
Majoritarian / Alternative vote	Winner needs 50%+1 (runoff / ranked-choice)
Proportional representation (PR)	Seats = vote share (closed-list / open-list; threshold)
Mixed / semiproportional	SMD seats + party-list PR (compensatory / noncompensatory)
Duverger's Law	SMD → two parties; PR → multiparty
Party system	Number & strength of parties (dominant / two-party / multiparty)
Programmatic / patronage / populist mobilisation	Win support by ideas / material rewards / anti-elite personalism
Interest-group pluralism	Many competing groups, neutral state (US)
Neocorporatism	Few peak associations bargain binding deals with the state (Germany)
Peak association	Body uniting a whole sector to negotiate with the state
Social capital	Networks + norms of reciprocity underpinning civil society
Powell trade-off	Diverse representation ⇔ clear accountability

Exam pointers

- Reproduce the electoral-systems comparison cold — how each converts votes→seats, its effect on the **number of parties (Duverger)**, **proportionality**, **turnout**, and **women/minorities** — with a case each.
 - Answer both spine questions: **why participate** (collective-action problem; institutions shape turnout) and **whose interests get represented** (electoral → party → interest-group chain).
 - State Duverger's Law and its limits (India; France 2017).
 - Contrast pluralism vs neocorporatism (US vs Germany) for interest representation.
 - Land on the Powell trade-off (representation ⇔ accountability) and the robust finding that **PR represents women better**; use **Iversen & Soskice** to link PR → more redistribution.
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★ Fun facts & memorable details

Sticky stats, dates & quotes from Lecture 5 (participation & representation).

Quotable

- Schattschneider (1942): "*Modern democracy is unthinkable save in terms of parties.*"
- Downs (1957): for most people, voting is technically **irrational** — the seed of the collective-action problem.
- Powell's master **trade-off**: representation/participation $\rightleftharpoons$ accountability/governability.

Striking numbers

- **UK 2015**: UKIP won **12.6%** → **1 seat**; the SNP won *fewer* votes → **56 seats**.
- **US 2012 House**: in the ten most gerrymandered states, Republicans won **7% more votes but 76% more seats**.
- **Israel**: whole country = one district; **3.25% threshold**; **three elections in one year (2019)**; governments last ~2 years.
- **India**: parties grew **50 (1952) → 342 (2009)**; **120 of ~600** seats reserved for lower castes/tribes; BJP 2014 = **31% of vote → 52% of seats**.
- **Brazil 2018**: its most fragmented legislature ever — **30 parties**.
- **Women in legislatures**: Nordic countries lead at **42.5%**; US House only **23.4%** (2019). Robust finding: **PR elects more women than SMD**.
- Only ~**20%** of citizens trust parties, though ~**80%** call democracy "a very good thing."
- **Maine 2018**: first US Congress seat decided by **ranked-choice** — Golden won 50.5–49.5 after trailing on the first count.

Memorable

- **France**: the top two parties held **56% of Assembly seats (1973) → 82% (2012)** — then the system **collapsed in 2017** with Macron's one-year-old party.
- ~**60 countries** used FPTP in 2019 — almost all former British colonies; **Belarus** was the only continental-European one.
- The social-capital debate in two titles: Putnam's *Bowling Alone* vs its rebuttal "**Kicking in Groups**."